only get blocked with snowfall sometime in the latter half of January, and only for a couple of months.

Anant Pathania was again connected with IV Corps shortly around 10.30 p.m. The ‘no withdrawal’ signal sent to 4 Division by Corps HQ via Bomdila had reached Pathania an hour ago. In Tezpur, the three generals were at dinner when the call came through. Palit picked up the phone. Even as he waited for Kaul to get to the phone, Palit told the GOC, ‘Anant, there is to be no withdrawal. The corps commander will tell you that himself.’ Palit then asked Pathania if there had been a frontal attack on the Se-la positions. Pathania said no, there was no contact, but there were reports that the Chinese were active between Bomdila and Dirang and also between Senge and Dirang.

Recorded Palit: ‘At this point Kaul took the line from me and a drawn out conversation ensued. There was much reference back and forth to Thapar, who for once was definitive that there was to be no withdrawal. At last Bijji Kaul gave his subordinate commander orders for battle—in words which will surely remain a classic *double entendre* in our military history books. ‘Achchha, Anant,’ Bijji said in Hindi, ‘For tonight you hang on to your defences.’ Then in English he added, ‘Have another chat with me in the morning!’ How far that unconventional enjoinment would stand up as an imperative to a jittery subordinate to stay and fight, I need not comment upon—but it was too late to do anything about it.’

Back on Se-la, subsequent to the conversation with Pathania where the GOC kept emphasizing the deteriorating situation in Bomdila and elsewhere all along the line of communication, Hoshiar Singh seems to have finally lost his nerve. He decided to withdraw 2 Sikh LI into the inner perimeter of Se-la. Orders to this effect were passed to Irani at around 11 p.m. This order was changed shortly afterwards, and the battalion was ordered to go through to Nyukmadong. They were to start withdrawing after 4 Sikh LI had fallen back from the Two Lakes area and occupied their positions within the main defences. The revised order bordered on the ludicrous; Hoshiar Singh wanted a battalion dug in at Se-la Top whose positions were being probed by the Chinese to get up in the middle of the night and withdraw to a place no one was even familiar with. His revised plan also meant clockwork precision involving 1 Sikh, 2 and 4 Sikh LI. Even had this been rehearsed, the coordination required for this task was virtually impossible.